Himaayah Schools
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FREE GUIDE

آمَنَ الرَّسُولُ بِمَا أُنزِلَ إِلَيْهِ مِن رَّبِّهِ وَالْمُؤْمِنُونَ

"The Messenger has believed in what was revealed to him from his Lord, and so have the believers." (al-Baqarah 2:285)

The Six Pillars of Īmān

Belief in Allah, His angels, His books, His messengers, the Last Day and the decree, explained simply with the evidence.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

ʿUmar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb said: one day, while we were sitting with the Messenger of Allah ﷺ, a man came to us with very white clothes and very black hair. No sign of travel could be seen on him, and none of us knew him. He sat before the Prophet ﷺ, knee to knee, and asked him about Islām, then about īmān, then about iḥsān, then about the Hour. When he left, the Prophet ﷺ said: "That was Jibrīl. He came to teach you your religion" (Muslim, 8).

> أَنْ تُؤْمِنَ بِاللَّهِ، وَمَلَائِكَتِهِ، وَكُتُبِهِ، وَرُسُلِهِ، وَالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ، وَتُؤْمِنَ بِالْقَدَرِ خَيْرِهِ وَشَرِّهِ
>
> **"[Īmān is] that you believe in Allah, His angels, His books, His messengers and the Last Day, and that you believe in the decree, its good and its bad."**
>
> From the ḥadīth of Jibrīl (Muslim, 8).

These are the six pillars of īmān. Every Muslim must believe in all of them; denying any one of them is disbelief. This guide explains each pillar simply, with its evidence from the Qur'an and Sunnah, what it includes, and how it changes the way a believer lives. It follows the creed of **Ahl as-Sunnah wal-Jamāʿah**, taught in the opening chapter of the Risālah of Ibn Abī Zayd and in our Madrasah.

How to use this guide

Learn the evidence for each pillar by heart: one verse and one ḥadīth.

Discuss the "What it does to the heart" sections with your family or class.

Questions of belief need a teacher. Where a matter is deep or debated among the scholars, ask your teacher rather than the internet.

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Part 1 Islām, īmān and iḥsān

Level	What the Prophet ﷺ said	In short
Islām	"That you testify there is no god but Allah and Muḥammad is the Messenger of Allah, establish the prayer, give zakāh, fast Ramaḍān, and perform Ḥajj to the House if you are able."	The outward acts of submission
Īmān	"That you believe in Allah, His angels, His books, His messengers, the Last Day, and the decree, its good and its bad."	The inward beliefs of the heart
Iḥsān	"That you worship Allah as though you see Him; and if you do not see Him, He sees you."	The highest level: worship with full awareness

Īmān is belief in the heart, declaration with the tongue, and action with the limbs. The three levels are like circles one inside the other: every muḥsin is a muʾmin, and every muʾmin is a Muslim.

Pillar 1 Belief in Allah

قُلْ هُوَ اللَّهُ أَحَدٌ ﴿١﴾ اللَّهُ الصَّمَدُ ﴿٢﴾ لَمْ يَلِدْ وَلَمْ يُولَدْ ﴿٣﴾ وَلَمْ يَكُن لَّهُ كُفُوًا أَحَدٌ

"Say: He is Allah, One. Allah, the Eternal Refuge. He neither begets nor is born, and there is none comparable to Him."

Sūrat al-Ikhlāṣ (112). The Prophet ﷺ said it is equal to a third of the Qur'an (al-Bukhārī, 5013).

What it includes

- **His existence.** The heavens, the earth and our own selves point to a Creator: "Or were they created by nothing, or were they the creators?" (aṭ-Ṭūr 52:35). Every person is born with this knowledge in his nature (fiṭrah) (al-Bukhārī 1385, Muslim 2658).
- **He alone is the Lord:** the Creator, the Owner and the Disposer of all things. Nothing happens in the universe except by His will.
- **He alone deserves worship.** Prayer, duʿāʾ, sacrifice, vows, fear and hope in what only Allah can do, and trust, are for Allah alone. This is the meaning of "lā ilāha illā Allāh", and it is the message of every prophet (an-Naḥl 16:36). Worshipping anything with Allah is shirk, the one sin Allah does not forgive for one who dies upon it (an-Nisāʾ 4:48).
- **His beautiful names and perfect attributes.** We affirm what Allah affirmed for Himself in the Qur'an and what His Messenger ﷺ affirmed, without likening Him to creation and without denying what He said. "There is nothing like Him, and He is the All-Hearing, the All-Seeing" (ash-Shūrā 42:11).

Some of His names

Name	Meaning	Name	Meaning
Ar-Raḥmān	The Most Merciful	Al-ʿAlīm	The All-Knowing
Ar-Raḥīm	The Especially Merciful	Al-Ḥakīm	The All-Wise
Al-Malik	The King	Al-Ghafūr	The Forgiving
Al-Quddūs	The Most Pure	Ar-Razzāq	The Provider
As-Salām	The Source of Peace	Al-Wadūd	The Loving
Al-Khāliq	The Creator	Al-Ḥayy al-Qayyūm	The Ever-Living, the Sustainer

"Allah has ninety-nine names, one hundred minus one. Whoever learns them and lives by them (aḥṣāhā) will enter Paradise" (al-Bukhārī 2736, Muslim 2677).

What it does to the heart

Love of Allah, hope in His mercy and fear of His punishment; trust in Him in every difficulty; and freedom from fearing or begging any created being, because only He gives and withholds.

Pillar 2 Belief in the angels

The angels are a creation of Allah made from light (Muslim, 2996). They worship Allah without tiring and never disobey Him: “They do not disobey Allah in what He commands them, and they do what they are commanded” (at-Taḥrīm 66:6). They are not daughters of Allah, nor partners with Him, nor to be worshipped. We believe in those named in the Qur’an and Sunnah by name, and in the rest in general.

Angel	Task
Jibrīl	Brings revelation to the prophets (al-Baqarah 2:97). Called ar-Rūḥ al-Amīn, the Trustworthy Spirit.
Mīkāʾīl	Charged with rain and plants.
Isrāfīl	Will blow the Trumpet at the end of the world and for the resurrection.
The Angel of Death	Takes the souls at their appointed time (as-Sajdah 32:11).
Munkar and Nakīr	Question the dead in the grave (at-Tirmidhī, 1071).
The honourable scribes (al-Kirām al-Kātibūn)	Record every deed, good and bad (al-Infiṭār 82:10–12; Qāf 50:17–18).
Mālik	The keeper of Hell (az-Zukhruf 43:77).
The guardians (al-ḥafaẓah)	Protect each person by Allah’s command (ar-Raʿd 13:11).

What it does to the heart

Shyness before the angels who are always with us, care in what we say and do because it is written, and gratitude to Allah for their protection. The angels make duʿāʾ for those who teach people good (at-Tirmidhī, 2685).

Pillar 3 Belief in the books

Allah revealed books to His messengers as guidance and light. We believe in them all in general, and in those named specifically:

Book	Revealed to
The Ṣuḥuf (scrolls)	Ibrāhīm and Mūsā (al-Aʿlā 87:19)
The Tawrāh	Mūsā
The Zabūr	Dāwūd (an-Nisāʾ 4:163)
The Injīl	ʿĪsā
The Qur'an	Muḥammad ﷺ, for all people until the Last Day

The earlier books were changed and lost over time (al-Baqarah 2:79; al-Māʾidah 5:13). The Qur'an is the speech of Allah, preserved by Him: "Indeed, it is We who sent down the reminder, and indeed, We will be its guardian" (al-Ḥijr 15:9). It confirms what was true in the earlier books and stands over them (al-Māʾidah 5:48). Belief in it means reading it, understanding it, obeying it and judging by it.

Pillar 4 Belief in the messengers

آمَنَ الرَّسُولُ بِمَا أُنزِلَ إِلَيْهِ مِن رَّبِّهِ وَالْمُؤْمِنُونَ ۚ كُلٌّ آمَنَ بِاللَّهِ وَمَلَائِكَتِهِ وَكُتُبِهِ وَرُسُلِهِ لَا نُفَرِّقُ بَيْنَ أَحَدٍ مِّن رُّسُلِهِ

"The Messenger has believed in what was revealed to him from his Lord, and so have the believers. All of them have believed in Allah, His angels, His books and His messengers: we make no distinction between any of His messengers."

Al-Baqarah 2:285.

- Allah sent messengers to every nation (an-Naḥl 16:36), all calling to the worship of Allah alone. Twenty-five are named in the Qur'an; the five greatest are **Ūlu al-ʿAzm**: Nūḥ, Ibrāhīm, Mūsā, ʿĪsā and Muḥammad ﷺ.
- The prophets are human beings chosen by Allah. They were **truthful**, **trustworthy**, **conveyed the message** completely, and were **intelligent and wise**. They were protected from major sins and from error in conveying the message.
- They had no share in divinity and knew of the unseen only what Allah taught them (al-Jinn 72:26–27).
- **Muḥammad ﷺ is the Seal of the Prophets** (al-Aḥzāb 33:40), sent to all mankind and jinn. There is no prophet after him. Belief in him means obeying his commands, believing his reports, avoiding what he forbade, and worshipping Allah only as he taught.
- ʿĪsā (peace be upon him) was raised alive and will return before the Hour, ruling by the law of Muḥammad ﷺ (al-Bukhārī 3448, Muslim 155).

The 25 prophets named in the Qur'an

Ādam · Idrīs · Nūḥ · Hūd · Ṣāliḥ · Ibrāhīm · Lūṭ · Ismāʿīl · Isḥāq · Yaʿqūb · Yūsuf · Ayyūb · Shuʿayb · Mūsā · Hārūn · Dhul-Kifl · Dāwūd · Sulaymān · Ilyās · al-Yasaʿ · Yūnus · Zakariyyā · Yaḥyā · ʿĪsā · Muḥammad ﷺ

Pillar 5 Belief in the Last Day

Belief in the Last Day includes everything the Qur'an and authentic Sunnah tell us about what happens after death:

1. **The signs of the Hour.** Minor signs, many of which have appeared, and major signs: the Dajjāl, the descent of ʿĪsā, Yaʾjūj and Maʾjūj, the sun rising from the west and others (Muslim, 2901). Its time is known only to Allah (Luqmān 31:34).
2. **The grave (al-barzakh).** The questioning by the two angels: Who is your Lord? What is your religion? Who is your prophet? The grave is a garden of Paradise or a pit of the Fire. The Prophet ﷺ sought refuge from the punishment of the grave in every prayer (Muslim, 588).
3. **The blowing of the Trumpet and the resurrection.** All will be raised barefoot, naked and uncircumcised (al-Bukhārī 6527, Muslim 2859) and gathered for judgement.
4. **The reckoning and the records.** Each person is given his book in his right hand or his left (al-Ḥāqqah 69:19–29).
5. **The scale (al-mīzān):** deeds are weighed with perfect justice (al-Anbiyāʾ 21:47).
6. **The pool (al-ḥawḍ)** of the Prophet ﷺ: whoever drinks from it will never thirst again (al-Bukhārī 6579).
7. **The intercession (ash-shafāʿah)** of the Prophet ﷺ, and of others by Allah's permission (al-Bukhārī 4712).
8. **The bridge (aṣ-ṣirāṭ)** over Hell, which people cross according to their deeds.
9. **Paradise and Hell**, which exist now and will never end. The greatest bliss of Paradise is seeing Allah (Muslim, 181).

What it does to the heart

It makes the believer take every deed seriously, bear injustice patiently knowing that justice is coming, and not be deceived by this world. "Be in this world as though you were a stranger or a traveller" (al-Bukhārī, 6416).

Pillar 6 Belief in the decree (al-qadar)

إِنَّا كُلَّ شَيْءٍ خَلَقْنَاهُ بِقَدَرٍ

“Indeed, all things We created with predestination.”

Al-Qamar 54:49.

Level	Meaning	Evidence
Knowledge (al-ʿilm)	Allah knows everything: what was, what is, what will be, and what would have been.	Al-Ḥajj 22:70
Writing (al-kitābah)	Allah wrote everything in the Preserved Tablet fifty thousand years before creating the heavens and the earth.	Muslim, 2653
Will (al-mashīʾah)	Nothing happens except by Allah’s will: what He wills is, and what He does not will is not.	At-Takwīr 81:29
Creation (al-khalq)	Allah is the Creator of all things, including the actions of His servants.	Aṣ-Ṣāffāt 37:96

And we have free choice. Allah gave us a will and the ability to choose, and we are rewarded or punished for what we choose (al-Insān 76:3; al-Kahf 18:29). We do not know what is written, so we do not use the decree as an excuse for sin. When the Companions asked: “Should we not rely on what is written and leave deeds?” he said: “Act, for each person is made easy for what he was created for” (al-Bukhārī 4949, Muslim 2647).

What it does to the heart

Peace in calamity, because what befell you was never going to miss you (at-Tirmidhī, 2516); no arrogance in success, because it is from Allah; and effort with reliance on Allah. “Strive for what benefits you, seek Allah’s help, and do not give up. If something befalls you, do not say ‘if only I had…’, but say: Allah decreed, and what He willed He did” (Muslim, 2664).

Part 8 Īmān grows and shrinks

Īmān increases with obedience and decreases with sin: “…that they may increase in faith along with their faith” (al-Fatḥ 48:4). The Prophet ﷺ said: “Īmān has seventy-odd branches; the highest is saying lā ilāha illā Allāh and the lowest is removing something harmful from the road, and modesty is a branch of īmān” (Muslim, 35).

What increases it	What weakens it
Learning about Allah, His names and His signs	Ignorance of the religion
Reciting and reflecting on the Qur'an	Heedlessness and too much entertainment
The prayer, dhikr and duʿāʾ	Sins, especially when persisted in
Good company and sitting with people of knowledge	Bad company
Remembering death and the Hereafter	Love of this world above the Hereafter

Test Self-test

Choose the best answer. The answers follow the questions.

1. Who came to teach the Companions their religion in the famous ḥadīth?

a) Jibrīl b) Mīkāʾīl c) An unknown traveller d) Khiḍr

2. How many pillars of īmān are there?

a) Five b) Four c) Seven d) Six

3. Iḥsān is:

a) Giving charity b) Worshipping Allah as though you see Him c) Praying in congregation d) Fasting Mondays

4. The one sin Allah does not forgive for one who dies upon it is:

a) Lying b) Missing a prayer c) Shirk d) Backbiting

5. The angel who brings revelation is:

a) Isrāfīl b) Jibrīl c) Mālik d) Munkar

6. The Zabūr was revealed to:

a) Mūsā b) ʿĪsā c) Ibrāhīm d) Dāwūd

7. How many prophets are named in the Qur'an?

a) 25 b) 5 c) 99 d) 313

8. The Seal of the Prophets is:

a) ʿĪsā b) Mūsā c) Muḥammad ﷺ d) Ibrāhīm

9. The greatest bliss of Paradise is:

a) Its rivers b) Seeing Allah c) Its palaces d) Its fruits

10. Allah wrote the decrees before creating the heavens and the earth by:

a) 1,000 years b) 7 days c) 50,000 years d) One year

11. Can a person use the decree as an excuse for sin?

a) Yes, always b) No: we have choice and are accountable c) Only for small sins d) Only children

12. Īmān:

a) Never changes b) Only increases c) Only decreases d) Increases with obedience and decreases with sin

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	a) Jibrīl	7	a) 25
2	d) Six	8	c) Muḥammad ﷺ
3	b) As though you see Him	9	b) Seeing Allah
4	c) Shirk	10	c) 50,000 years
5	b) Jibrīl	11	b) No
6	d) Dāwūd	12	d) Increases and decreases

For further study

- The opening chapter of **ar-Risālah** of Ibn Abī Zayd al-Qayrawānī, on what the tongue declares and the heart believes.
- **Al-ʿAqīdah aṭ-Ṭaḥāwiyyah** of Imām aṭ-Ṭaḥāwī, with a teacher's explanation.
- The **ḥadīth of Jibrīl** in an-Nawawī's Forty Ḥadīth, with a commentary.

Duʿāʾ — For a firm heart

يَا مُقَلِّبَ الْقُلُوبِ، ثَبِّتْ قَلْبِي عَلَى دِينِكَ

"O Turner of hearts, make my heart firm upon Your religion."

The duʿāʾ the Prophet ﷺ made most often (at-Tirmidhī, 2140).

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What the heart believes.

This free guide from the Himaayah Madrasah explains the six pillars of faith from the ḥadīth of Jibrīl, with the Qur'an and authentic Sunnah, for students and families.

- Islām, īmān and iḥsān
- Each pillar, with its evidence
- The angels and their tasks, the books and the prophets
- The grave, the resurrection, Paradise and Hell
- The decree and our free choice, and a self-test

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